

What Would You Do If Your Parents Called and Said, “We Need You to Send Us \$2,000”?

On an early episode of my podcast, I spoke to a Pakistani couple. The husband was struggling with how to respond to his parents' frequent and ever-increasing requests to send them money. As the eldest son, he was expected to come through—over and over again, no questions asked.

If you're Pakistani, Indian, Mexican, Ghanaian, Filipino, or from many other cultures, there's a good chance that you'll immediately understand these expectations. To others, this question might seem surprising, even ridiculous. But to many people around the world, the expectation of helping family with money is real.

We've spoken about the invisible scripts you grew up with (flip back to page 30). You've thought about how your parents modeled money (see facing page). Now I want you to consider how culture has affected your perspective on personal finance.

Cultural expectations are incredibly powerful, yet the rules are never actually written out. Still, you're pressured to follow them—and you face swift punishment if you don't.

Think about the cultural expectations you grew up with. Were you expected to become a doctor or engineer? (I was. So were most of my Indian friends.) Or were you expected to buy a house, have two kids, and move to the suburbs? That's a cultural expectation too, though if you grew up in America, you might not even recognize it as such—that's why it's an “invisible script.”

The solution here isn't to try to change culture singlehandedly. It is to clarify the invisible rules, because once we can see them, then we can start to decide if we actually want to follow them. For the couple above, the son realized that he had never actually said “no” to his parents—ever. He had to redefine his relationship with them and establish that his wife was his first priority. This is a daunting identity change that requires many difficult—but often necessary—conversations.